

Overview: Scaffolded Writing Frames

Scaffolded writing frames provide a visible structure that removes the overwhelming blank page. By offering sentence starters, paragraph templates, and clear organisational frameworks, pupils can focus on their ideas rather than struggling with how to begin or structure their writing. The key is to differentiate the level of scaffolding and gradually fade support as confidence grows.

When to Use This Strategy

- Pupil stares at blank page for extended periods
- Writing is disorganised with ideas jumping randomly
- Frequently asks "How do I start?" or "What do I write?"
- Produces very little written work despite verbal ability

Step-by-Step Guide

1 Assess the scaffolding level needed

Observe the pupil's current writing. Do they need complete sentence starters (high scaffold), opening words only (medium), or just structural prompts (low)? Match the frame to their current ability.

Tip: When in doubt, start with more scaffolding. You can always remove it.

2 Choose the right frame type

Select from: paragraph frames (topic sentence + supporting points + conclusion), PEEL frames simplified (Point, Evidence, Explain), story frames (beginning, middle, end with prompts), or subject-specific frames.

Teacher says: "Today I'm giving you a writing frame. It shows you exactly how to organise your answer."

Tip: Have multiple versions ready at different scaffold levels.

3 Model using the frame

Before independent work, demonstrate completing the frame. Think aloud as you use each sentence starter. Show how the frame guides you through the writing.

Teacher says: "Watch me use this frame. It says 'First...' so I'm going to write what happened first. Then it says 'Next...' so I move to what happened after that."

4 Provide the frame and check understanding

Give the pupil their frame. Point to each section. Check they understand what goes where before they begin writing.

Teacher says: "Point to where you'll write your first idea. Good. Point to where you'll give your evidence. Perfect."

Tip: Colour-code sections if helpful for visual learners.

5 Support without over-helping

During writing, redirect to the frame rather than giving answers. The frame should do the scaffolding work. If they're stuck, point to the next sentence starter.

Teacher says: "What does your frame say to write next? Read that sentence starter to me."

6 Plan for fading

Track progress. When the pupil consistently completes a frame confidently, move to a lighter scaffold. The goal is independent writing, with frames as a stepping stone.

Tip: Fading might take weeks or months. Don't rush it.

English Example: Writing a paragraph about a character

Year 8 studying *Of Mice and Men*. Pupil working at KS2 level needs to write a paragraph about Lennie.

Provide paragraph frame

Teacher: Give pupil a paragraph frame: "Lennie is... This is shown when he... This tells the reader that... Another example is when... Overall, Lennie..."

Pupil: Sees the structure. Knows there are five parts to complete.

Model the first sentence

Teacher: Say: "Watch me start. 'Lennie is...' I need a word to describe him. I'll write 'Lennie is kind.' Now you try the next part."

Pupil: Sees how to use the starter. Attempts "This is shown when he..."

Guide through the frame

Teacher: Point to each section in turn. "Read the next starter. What goes there? Find something from the text."

Pupil: Works through frame systematically. Completes each section.

Review completed paragraph

Teacher: Say: "Read me your whole paragraph." Praise the structure. "See how your frame helped you write a proper paragraph with evidence?"

Pupil: Reads complete paragraph. Sees they've produced structured writing.

Maths Example: Explaining mathematical reasoning

Year 9 explaining how they solved a problem. Pupil working at KS2 level can do the maths but cannot explain their thinking in writing.

Provide reasoning frame

Teacher: Give frame: "To solve this problem, I first... I did this because... Then I... My answer is... I know this is correct because..."

Pupil: Sees structure for explaining their method.

Walk through their solution

Teacher: Say: "You got the right answer. Now let's explain how. What did you do first? Write that after 'I first...'"

Pupil: Recalls first step. Writes: "I first multiplied 12 by 5."

Prompt reasoning

Teacher: Point to "I did this because..." Say: "Why did you multiply? What made you choose that operation?"

Pupil: Thinks about reasoning. Writes: "because I needed to find the total."

Complete explanation

Teacher: Guide through remaining starters. "Now you have a full written explanation. Anyone reading this would understand your method."

Pupil: Completes frame. Has structured mathematical explanation.

Science Example: Writing a conclusion

Year 7 writing up an experiment on dissolving. Pupil working at KS1 level struggles to structure ideas and needs writing support.

Provide conclusion frame

Teacher: Give simple frame: "I found out that... I know this because... This happened because... If I did this again, I would..."

Pupil: Sees four clear sentences to complete.

Connect to their results

Teacher: Point to their results table. "Look at your results. What did you find out? Write that after 'I found out that...'"

Pupil: Looks at results. Writes finding: "sugar dissolved fastest."

Support evidence sentence

Teacher: Point to next starter. "'I know this because...'" Look at your numbers. What do they tell you?"

Pupil: Refers to data. Writes evidence: "it took only 30 seconds."

Complete and celebrate

Teacher: Guide through remaining sentences. "You've written a full scientific conclusion using your frame. This is exactly what scientists do."

Pupil: Finishes all four sentences. Has complete conclusion.